

Word family: **mute / muted / muting**

Base word: mute

Past tense: muted

Past participle: muted

Related forms: muted, muting

Part of speech: adjective (形容詞) / verb (動詞) / noun (名詞)

Your sentence:

> “It was like someone had pressed a **mute** button on the outside world, and that image really stayed with me.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **mute** describes a button or function that **turns sound off**.

Meaning: A control that stops sound from being heard without necessarily stopping the device, video, call, etc.

繁體中文: **把裝置、影片、通話等的聲音關掉，但不一定停止其本身運作的靜音功能**

中文翻譯:

> “It was like someone had pressed a mute button on the outside world...”

「那感覺就像有人替整個外界**按下了靜音鍵**一樣.....」

mute button = 用來關閉聲音輸出的靜音按鈕

1. **mute = button/function (按鈕 / 功能) that turns sound off — 靜音的；用來關閉聲音的**

This is the meaning in your original sentence.

Practice 1 — Original

> “It was like someone had pressed a **mute** button on the outside world.”

「那感覺就像有人替整個外界**按下了靜音鍵**一樣。」

Practice 2

> “Press the **mute** button if you don’t want to hear the video.”

「如果你不想聽到影片的聲音，就按下**靜音鍵**。」

Practice 3

> “I couldn’t hear anything because the television was on **mute**.”

「我甚麼都聽不到，因為電視處於**靜音狀態**。」

****mute = 與關閉聲音輸出有關，使裝置繼續運作但不發出可聽聲音的****

2. ****mute + device/audio/call (裝置 / 聲音 / 通話) — 把……靜音；關掉聲音****

Here, ****mute**** is a verb.

****Meaning:**** To stop sound from being heard from a device, application, call, microphone, etc.

Practice 4

> “I ****muted**** the television during the advertisement.”

「廣告播放時，我把電視**調成靜音**。」

Practice 5

> “Please ****mute**** your microphone when you’re not speaking.”

「你不說話時，請把麥克風**靜音**。」

****mute something = 關閉某個聲音來源或音訊輸入 / 輸出，使其暫時沒有聲音****

3. ****mute + person/account/chat/notification (人 / 帳戶 / 聊天 / 通知) — 暫停接收其聲音或通知****

This is an important modern technology extension.

****Meaning:**** To prevent notifications, messages, audio, or alerts from a particular source from disturbing you, without necessarily blocking or removing that source.

Practice 6

> “I ****muted**** the group chat for eight hours.”

「我把群組聊天**設成八小時不發通知**。」

Practice 7

> “You can **mute** an account without unfollowing it.”

「你可以把某個帳戶**設為不顯示 / 不通知其更新**，而不用取消追蹤。」

****mute = 暫時停止某個人、聊天或帳戶產生通知 / 聲音，而不一定封鎖或刪除它****

This is broader than literal audio muting.

4. ****be on mute / have something on mute (裝置 / 麥克風) — 處於靜音狀態****

A very common modern expression.

Practice 8

> “Your microphone is still **on mute**.”

「你的麥克風仍然處於**靜音狀態**。」

Practice 9

> “I usually keep my phone **on mute** during meetings.”

「開會時，我通常會把手機保持在**靜音模式**。」

****on mute = 聲音功能已被暫時關閉的狀態****

5. ****mute = person unable or unwilling to speak (人) — 無法說話的；不開口的****

This is an older/core adjective meaning from which the sound-related sense developed.

****Meaning:**** Unable to speak, or remaining completely silent.

Practice 10

> “He stood **mute** with shock.”

「他震驚得**一句話也說不出來**。」

Practice 11

> “She remained ****mute**** throughout the questioning.”

「整個問話過程中，她一直****保持沉默、不開口回答****。」

****mute = 因無法、震驚、選擇等原因而完全不說話的****

Usage note

Using ****“a mute”**** as a noun for a person who cannot speak is now generally considered ****dated and potentially disrespectful****.

Modern English usually prefers a more precise description such as:

* ****a person who cannot speak****

* ****a non-speaking person****

* ****a person with a speech disability****

So we should recognize the older noun use if encountered, but ****not recommend it as ordinary modern usage****.

6. ****mute = sound/voice (聲音) very quiet or suppressed — 微弱的；被壓低的****

****Meaning:**** Quietened, restrained, or prevented from being heard at full strength.

Practice 12

> “A ****mute**** cry came from the next room.”

「隔壁房間傳來一聲****被壓低、幾乎聽不清的叫聲****。」

Practice 13

> “The thick walls made the sounds outside seem ****muted****.”

「厚牆令外面的聲音聽起來****被壓低、變得微弱****。」

In modern everyday English, ****muted**** is much more common than bare ****mute**** for this sense.

7. ****muted = sound/voice (聲音 / 噪音) reduced in volume or intensity — 被壓低的；柔和微弱的****

****Meaning:**** Made quieter or less intense rather than completely silent.

Practice 14

> “We could hear ****muted**** voices through the wall.”

「我們隔著牆聽到一些****被壓低、模糊微弱的說話聲****。」

Practice 15

> “The music continued at a ****muted**** volume.”

「音樂以****較低、柔和的音量****繼續播放。」

****muted sound = 聲音強度受到抑制，比原本更柔和或微弱，但不一定完全沒有聲音****

Very important:

****muted ≠ always completely silent****

8. ****muted = colour/design (顏色 / 設計) soft, subdued, not bright — 柔和低調、不鮮艷的****

This is a very common figurative sense.

****Meaning:**** Not bright, vivid, or strongly contrasting.

Practice 16

> “The room was decorated in ****muted**** colours.”

「房間採用了****柔和低調、不鮮艷的色彩****裝飾。」

Practice 17

> “The designer chose a ****muted**** green for the walls.”

「設計師為牆身選了一種****低飽和、柔和的綠色****。」

****muted colour = 飽和度或視覺強度較低，不鮮艷、不搶眼的顏色****

9. ****muted = reaction/emotion/response (反應 / 情緒) restrained and not strongly expressed —**

克制的；反應不強烈的**

****Meaning:**** Present, but expressed with relatively little enthusiasm, emotion, or intensity.

Practice 18

> “The announcement received a ****muted**** response.”

「這項公布只得到****相當平淡、不太熱烈的反應****。」

Practice 19

> “There was ****muted**** excitement in the office.”

「辦公室裡有一種****受到克制、沒有強烈表露的興奮情緒****。」

****muted reaction/emotion** = 情緒或反應存在，但表現得克制、低調而不強烈**

This develops naturally from “reducing the volume” metaphorically.

10. ****muted** = style/appearance (風格 / 外觀) restrained and understated — 低調的；不張揚的

****Meaning:**** Deliberately restrained rather than bright, dramatic, or attention-seeking.

Practice 20

> “The advertisement used a ****muted**** visual style.”

「這則廣告採用了****低調克制、不搶眼的視覺風格****。」

Practice 21

> “She wore a ****muted**** grey suit.”

「她穿了一套****色調低調、不張揚的灰色西裝****。」

****muted style** = 視覺或表現方式受到刻意克制，不鮮艷、不誇張、不搶眼**

I would group #8–#10 under one broad figurative concept:

> ****reduced intensity****

but keep the contextual Chinese distinct.

11. ****mute = musical device (樂器配件) — 弱音器****

Here, ****mute**** is a noun.

****Meaning:**** A device fitted to certain musical instruments to reduce or alter their sound.

Practice 22

> “The trumpet player used a ****mute**** during the second piece.”

「小號手在第二首樂曲中使用了****弱音器****。」

Practice 23

> “She placed a ****mute**** on the violin.”

「她在小提琴上裝上了****弱音器****。」

****mute = 裝在某些樂器上，用來降低音量或改變音色的裝置****

12. ****mute + musical instrument (樂器) — 用弱音器降低 / 改變樂器聲音****

Here, ****mute**** is a verb.

Practice 24

> “The composer asked the musicians to ****mute**** their trumpets.”

「作曲家要求樂手為小號****加上弱音器，以降低或改變音色****。」

Practice 25

> “The strings were ****muted**** for this section.”

「這一段弦樂採用了****弱音效果****。」

****mute an instrument = 使用弱音器或其他方式使樂器聲音變得較弱或音色有所改變****

13. ****muting = act/process of silencing or reducing sound — 靜音；降低聲音的操作****

Practice 26

> “Automatic microphone **muting** reduces background noise.”

「自動麥克風**靜音功能**可以減少背景噪音。」

Practice 27

> “The app supports notification **muting**.”

「這個應用程式支援通知**靜音 / 停用提醒功能**。」

muting = 暫時關閉聲音、通知或其他干擾來源的操作或過程

Important distinction: **mute** vs **silent**

silent

= producing no sound

> “The room was silent.”

「房間完全安靜，沒有聲音。」

mute

Often means:

* sound has been deliberately turned off; or

* someone does not/cannot speak.

> “The television is on mute.”

「電視已調成靜音。」

So **silent** describes the absence of sound broadly; **mute** often implies **suppression** or **disabling** of sound.

Important distinction: **mute** vs **quiet**

quiet

= little sound

> “The office is quiet.”

「辦公室很安靜。」

mute

= no sound because it has been turned off or suppressed

> “The microphone is muted.”

「麥克風被靜音了。」

So:

quiet = 聲音很少 / 很小

muted = 聲音被刻意壓低或關掉

Important distinction: **mute vs muted**

mute

Often means fully silenced in technology:

> “The microphone is on mute.”

「麥克風已靜音。」

muted

Can mean:

1. silenced electronically; or
2. simply reduced/subdued in intensity.

> “muted voices”

does **not** necessarily mean completely silent voices.

It means:

****聲音被壓低、比較微弱。****

Important distinction: **mute vs block**

Especially useful online:

**mute**

= stop seeing/hearing notifications or content, often without the other person knowing

**block**

= prevent the person/account from contacting or interacting with you more directly

So:

> “I muted the group chat.”

「我關掉這個群組的通知。」

is very different from:

> “I blocked the account.”

「我封鎖了這個帳戶。」

Important distinction: **muted colours vs dull colours**

**muted colours**

Often positive/neutral:

****柔和、低飽和、低調的顏色****

**dull colours**

Often more negative:

****暗淡、缺乏生氣或不吸引人的顏色****

A sophisticated design may deliberately use ****muted colours****.

Family-extension note

Following our updated Golden Manual, these useful expressions belong in the practical ****mute**** family:

- * ****mute button**** = 靜音鍵
- * ****mute function**** = 靜音功能
- * ****on mute**** = 處於靜音狀態
- * ****mute a microphone**** = 把麥克風靜音
- * ****mute a chat**** = 關閉聊天通知
- * ****mute an account**** = 暫停看到 / 接收某帳戶的內容或通知
- * ****muted colours**** = 柔和低調的顏色
- * ****muted response**** = 不熱烈、較克制的反應
- * ****musical mute**** = 樂器弱音器

A useful conceptual key is:

> ****mute = suppress or reduce expression/output****

That output may be:

- * literal sound,
- * online notifications,
- * colour intensity,
- * emotional reaction,
- * musical volume.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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mute button/function	用來暫時關閉裝置或音訊輸出的靜音功能
mute audio/device/call	關閉某個聲音來源，使其暫時不產生可聽聲音
mute chat/account/notifications	暫停接收某來源的通知、聲音或內容，而不一定封鎖它
on mute	聲音功能已被暫時關閉的狀態
mute — person	因無法、震驚或選擇等原因而完全不開口的
muted sound/voice	聲音受到壓低，比原本更柔和或微弱的
muted colour	視覺強度 / 飽和度較低，柔和而不鮮艷的
muted reaction/emotion	情緒或反應存在，但表現得克制、不強烈的
muted style	整體表現低調克制、不誇張或不搶眼的
mute — musical device	裝在樂器上、用來降低音量或改變音色的弱音器
mute an instrument	使用弱音方式降低或改變樂器的聲音

| ****muting**** | 暫時關閉或降低聲音、通知等輸出的操作 |

For your original sentence

> “It was like someone had pressed a ****mute button**** on the outside world...”

The exact meaning is:

****mute = 把聲音輸出關閉，使原本可以聽見的聲音暫時消失的****

So:

****press a mute button on the outside world****

is a metaphor meaning:

****戴上降噪耳機後，外界的聲音突然大幅減弱，感覺就像整個外界都被切換到「靜音模式」。****